

1. Introduction

At the dawn of time, humanity was swimming in an ocean of ignorance. It was a common belief that sickness was caused by evil spirits or as punishment for sin. Many so-called treatments were a form of torture. In this early world, there was no knowledge of medicine and no hope of finding a cause for sickness. It was, in short, the dark ages of medicine. Fast forward to the present day, where we are living in a time where a doctor can take a single drop of a patient's blood and fully map out the patient's DNA, instantly getting insight into genetic diseases and which medications the patient would respond best to. The advancements made in all professions since the beginning of humanity have been vast and impressive, to say the least. They have shaped the world we know today, influenced the sciences, arts, and politics, and ultimately allowed society to evolve. With this in mind, it is a safe assumption that the work done by professionals has had a major impact on this world. According to Bailey, "work is anything that a person does that takes up time, effort, and energy." Given this definition, work is not exclusive to a job. It is possible to be working when doing something that one loves or when helping someone in need. Because of this, each person is capable of being a professional in numerous fields throughout their life. Professionals are the ones who perform the work that they have been trained for. Their work is by no means a waste of time because it is often the work of professionals that has served as a catalyst for change in the world. The primary goal of many professionals is to cause a positive change. For example, it is a physician's goal to help a sick patient recover, and a teacher's goal to give their students the knowledge and guidance they need to grow up and be successful. A positive change can occur with a single person or to a whole society, and it can take time to come into effect. This change is the result of work put forth by professionals.

2. Importance of Professions in Society

Concise and practical as it may sound, the importance of professions in society can never be underestimated for the reason that they play a pivotal role in the sustenance of an orderly and peaceful world. As the late Sybil Collinson rightly put, "work in a modern society is more than an economic necessity; it is an essential source of personal identity, self-esteem, and social status." On a larger context, this statement holds true for it is reflective of the world macroscopically. This refers to the global identification, global self-esteem, and global social status of those who can otherwise be segmented into individual countries. The identity of a country on a global platform comes in the form of the standard of living enjoyed by its people. And in order to have a high international standard of living, a strong economy is essential. In other words, it is a developed country that has high self-esteem. Here, a key indication of a strong economy is one that is resilient towards economic shock and able to provide full employment. And it is the professions that form the backbone in creating and maintaining such an economy. Evidently, it is through the various professionals, their goods, and services that will collectively turn the wheels of the economy. By contributing to this economic development, professions also help to enhance the standard of living through increased income and job options. Take the example of a medical specialist who moves to a rural area. Up to his arrival, healthcare services in the area would have been minimal and most likely, the community would have needed to fork out large sums of money to seek treatment elsewhere. His presence would increase the availability of such services at a lower opportunity cost and help to improve the health of the community. Using the resources that he brings in, it is probable that a portion of the community will seek employment in the various services he creates. This would lead to increased job options and the income multiplier effect will further add to the prosperity of the community. So be it at the micro or macro level, the work of the professional is a strong determinant of the welfare of the society. At the individual level, the welfare of the society is an aggregate of individual welfare. Hence, for society to have welfare, individuals must first attain it. Coming to Maslow's hierarchical theory, the most basic form of individual welfare is the satisfaction of physiological and safety needs. This is a prerequisite to higher-level needs. Thus, the earlier the mentioned medical specialist supports his community, the sooner it can achieve higher-level needs. Now compare this with the situation in which he did not move into the area. The community would have remained in the same state for a longer duration. Hence, it can be inferred that his movement to the area has accelerated the rate of welfare of the community.

2.1. Contributions to Economic Development

The concept of a profession, which involves prolonged training and a formal qualification, with the key idea of service to others, is a valid and important concept. Professions exist in every social system and are an

important aspect of the functional integration of a society. Parsons defined a profession as a vocation. Primarily, it is a type of work with a conscious orientation to systematic training, based on the intellectual grasp of the content of knowledge, and with a constant responsibility to others. Parsons claimed that a profession is a full-time occupation, and many social workers would satisfy this aspect of the definition. However, many also work on a voluntary basis. Although the profession can be seen as a full-time occupation, it is not to be confused with the idea of full-time work. It is a carving out of a career. It requires the professional to be constantly developing their skills and knowledge and dedicating more and more time and effort to their vocational activity with the intention that it will become their main source of income. Parsons goes on to say that a profession involves the idea of responsible service to others. This is a crucial statement. The primary focus of all professions is to serve. Parsons only recognizes service that benefits others, stating that it is something which benefits a client with regard to the relevant problem the professional is trained to deal with. This would narrow the act of service down to requiring the use of specific skills and knowledge related to the professional activity and employment of technique to help solve problems. This also is relevant to the majority of social work client groups. Finally, a profession is distinguished by autonomy, where the professional is self-employed and has independence of action subject to legal controls of the professional field. This contrasts sharply with other types of employment in the social service sector, where workers are often given tasks and instructions and have little control over the work that they do.

2.2. Enhancing Social Welfare

A profession is an occupation that requires extensive education or specialized training. It is a vocation that its members consider to be more than a means of livelihood, one that involves a commitment to work in a field with recognized aims, and for the general advancement of these aims. Professions are considered to be a cornerstone of society since they provide an essential service to its members and to organized institutions. Thus, it is important for us to consider how they contribute to the betterment of society and the various ways in which they do so. One of the key ways in which professions contribute to society is by enhancing social welfare. Social welfare directly concerns the quality of life in a society. It is the global well-being of society and the various social, political, and economic structures that support this well-being. Professions enhance social welfare in many ways. A profession has a responsibility to attend to the problems and needs of society in its special areas and to assist in the solution of these problems. It does this through the provision of a service. The primary and most effective way in which a profession enhances social welfare is through the provision of its services. These services can encompass a vast array of things; some professional services are directed to assist people to better themselves in the sense of self-sufficiency and assistance. This can be seen in the work of social workers who assist the down and out in getting back on their own feet. Other services are preventative measures against some harmful occurrence or condition and seeking its eradication. An example of this would be the health education provided by medical professions on the dangers of a sedentary lifestyle and overeating, seeking to curb the rising problem of obesity in western societies. These services can be seen in the solving of specific social problems and the establishment of public policy. An example of this kind of work is the establishment of the Australian Institute of Criminology, which seeks to help solve the various problems of crime in Australia. Professional services can be a long-term attempt to assist a particular group or section of society and seek its empowerment and improvement in life quality. This can be seen in the work of the education profession, and education is the key to improvement in almost any human endeavor. With systems advocacy, there is an effort to build a better functioning society through change in various social systems. A clear statement from the nursing profession in relation to the resolution passed by the House of Delegates in 1998, that social policies must be directed towards improving health and primarily on the needs of people who are vulnerable. The provision of personal services for populations, communities, and individuals is the most diverse way in which a profession serves the public.

2.3. Promoting Individual Growth and Fulfillment

Individual growth and self-improvement are important values in Western society, seeking to be individuals with a greater sense of well-being. The medieval family life consisted of a self-sufficient unit living off the produce from the land. However, people now experience an increasing use of leisure with the time and resources to develop their own interests and talents. In order to do so, people must be earning a decent wage and have job security. Involvement in interesting and high-status work is linked to intelligence and personal competence, leading to raised self-esteem and a sense of accomplishment. Step by step, professionals are taking the place of the traditional folk-hero, acting as role models for the up-and-coming generation, not only

in social mobility but in achieving personal goals. A professional career is often a lifetime commitment. After investing time into education and training, individuals are in their jobs for the long run. Many people within all different levels of employment express dissatisfaction about their jobs. For example, the cleaner who is devalued and underpaid for the hard work they do, but is unable to leave for obvious reasons. A professional is able to spend their lives doing work that interests and satisfies them. Contributing to the common good makes them feel as though they are having a positive effect on society. This helps to achieve self-actualization, reaching one's full potential and the inner desire to accomplish everything that they possibly can. This theory would suggest it is the small minority of people in underprivileged employment who strive to become professionals. However, it is these people who lack the resources and opportunities to get there. This is leading to fewer people wanting to take on jobs such as nursing and teaching, with the values and benefits of these jobs being eroded over time.

3. Challenges and Responsibilities of Professions

The challenges and responsibilities of a profession are two sides of the same coin. On the positive side, they provide a very high degree of autonomy in practice, considerable social status, a high level of specialized knowledge, intellectual challenge, and, at least for some, a high level of financial compensation. All of these factors are rewards to the individual professional person. In addition, there is a great deal of personal satisfaction, most often because the practitioner is able to help resolve a client's problem and improve their quality of life. On the negative side, the same autonomy means that decisions are often made without the input of others and are unilateral in terms of both process and outcome. This is particularly true for professionals in adversarial situations, such as attorneys. While it is an advantage to the client if a lawyer's decision is the correct one for their cause, it often is a great personal burden to the lawyer if the decision has a negative outcome. This is especially true because of an external assessment often taking the form of sanctions against the professional, such as a malpractice judgment or a law society disciplinary measure. Other general disadvantages include the fact that professionals often work long hours for a low effective hourly wage; many professions also have a high psychological stress level. Underlying all of these advantages and disadvantages are the ethical considerations and responsibilities that are intrinsic to the professional status. Professional persons are unique in that they are given a mandate by society to control their own work, and that they alone possess the knowledge necessary to perform certain complex tasks. This giving of responsibility to individuals who are to act in the best interest of the public creates an implicit social contract between the profession and society. Failure to fulfill the terms of this contract may result in loss of autonomy in practice, as has been the case in the United States with physicians in managed care settings.

3.1. Ethical Considerations

A. There is a minimal tendency in the literature to deal directly with the question as to the nature of the ethics of a profession. It is the superiority of this ethics over that of ordinary men or over that of other groups in society which is usually taken for granted, rather than demonstrated or discussed. The concept of an ethic, as expressed in the quotations from Plato and Aristotle, is simply that it is a mode of conduct towards others which presupposes an ideal of self and of the relationships between individuals higher than the average. Now we have seen that all professions are in a sense a vocation, i.e. a calling to a type of work in which the need for the work is great and the motivation of the individual is not a mere desire to earn a living, but to attain to a high level of proficiency in the work for the work's own sake. It is not disputed that the vocation is the living through and in pursuit of an ideal, an ideal here of work well done. Now as self is merely that which desires and prescribes to itself what it holds before it as an ideal, any calling has a unique and specific ethics according as it has an ideal peculiar to itself. And the greater the divergence of a concrete calling from the average way of mankind, the more blunt will be the antithesis of the ethic of the calling with that of the average. This is a roundabout way of saying that the greater a departure of a calling from the ordinary the higher will be the standard expected of the practitioner by himself and by others. The physician "rights himself" to diagnose and treat, the lawyer to administer justice, in a manner different from chasing the physician a drug and the lawyer a fee, and to these men the failure in their professional duty is on their own admission, always a letting ourselves down rather than falling short of the standards of an external public opinion. But ideal and standards may be bad as well as good, and this ethic is still an ethic of its own class and type, despite the quality of the ideals and ideal conduct.

3.2. Ensuring Professional Competence

E1D03D - Level 5 - Scalar 3 As society grants professions the privilege of self-regulation, a contract is entered into in which professionals are entrusted to maintain competence and provide acceptable standards of practice. Over 23 years ago, the National Consumers' League identified the maintenance of competence as one of the four basic consumer rights, stating that "Consumers can expect qualified professionals and institutions providing services to consumers to maintain, on a continuing basis, and upgrade their knowledge and skills." There are several dimensions to the concept of ensuring professional competence. These include the structure of professional training, ongoing professional development, and mechanisms to ensure professional accountability. Structured professional training has traditionally been an important method in ensuring professional competence. Professions have set educational standards, often meaning that entry to a related profession is strictly limited to those who possess a certain level of education and/or training. Undertaking a specific form of training and education serves to legitimize the claim that an individual is a member of that profession. In essence, it states the difference between someone who utilizes the services of a professional (e.g., physiotherapy) and a professional physiotherapist. This is particularly important in the health industry because it allows people to identify those who are deemed competent to provide professional services. Once initial professional qualifications are achieved, there have been movements to establish some form of universal certification, such as the bar exam or specialist medical certifications. This serves to provide consumers of professional services with some evidence that the professional in question has maintained an acceptable level of competence. However, it must be noted that too stringent regulations regarding professional certification can lead to restrictions on trade and mobility of labor between professions. This has been a topic of debate in the European Union, which has implemented mechanisms such as the mutual recognition directive to facilitate trade in professional services between member states.

3.3. Balancing Personal and Professional Life

In many regards, professionals are no different from other working people. They too have families to support, mortgages and bills to pay, and hopes and dreams to pursue. In spite of this common ground with the rest of society, professional people frequently face dilemmas in which their actions diverge from the best interests of their families or friends. In the familiar example of the "doctor with a sick child," the professional is torn between the needs of his family and those of his clients or patients. Similar conflicts arise in many professions - business managers may lay off employees they personally like, but whose dismissal is in the interest of the company, while teachers may be pressured to "socially promote" students who have not learned the material. The interests of third parties, be they clients, customers, employers, or the public, are often contrasted with what is best for the professional's own kin or personal acquaintances. At its root, an issue of professional conduct that puts the professional interests in conflict with family interests reflects badly defined social expectations for that profession. When a lawyer is expected to bribe a judge to provide a favorable ruling for his client, at the expense of justice, it is apparent that something is amiss. When a judge is expected to rule in favor of the social or economic "elite" so that he may retain his position, then justice is doubly jeopardized. As issues such as these are a common source of professional dissatisfaction, it is increasingly important for professionals to engage in intraprofessional communication to define the true interests of the public. By clarifying public expectations and re-establishing the interests of clients and the general public in their respective professions, it becomes possible for professionals to align their work with the interests of their own families and friends, and still fulfill their professional responsibilities.